The Automation Playbook Workbook

One workbook that becomes your one-page Automation Playbook — the unit is always the **task**, never the tool. Fill it as the course goes; by the capstone the six tabs **are** your Playbook. The gray rows are the worked example — the 60-person firm's expense report coding task — write your own underneath.

The automation DRAFTS. A named human signs before anything is posted, paid, sent, or filed — you never automate the signature. Anything that touches money, compliance, or an action you can't take back stays a draft a person signs, every time, whatever the score.

1. **Score** your candidate tasks on five plain questions and read the verdict — Module 1.
2. **Choose** the lightest level of the ladder that does the job — Module 2.
3. **Author** the SOP your automation runs on, and point the SOP-Execution Agent at it — Module 3.
4. **Launch** the smallest safe version, with the human's sign-off designed in — Module 4.
5. **Evaluate** it: test the exceptions, arm the pivot switch, measure baseline vs after — Module 5.

S · SCORE	C · CHOOSE	A · AUTHOR	L · LAUNCH	E · EVALUATE
Automatability Scorecard	Approach Pick	Task SOP + Agent	Launch Card	Test / Rollback / Yield

Your Starting Snapshot — the task you're bringing

You arrive from Tasks, Not Jobs with one task you already decided to automate — your First Move.

Field	Your First Move	Example — the firm's expense report coding task
The task (verb + noun)		*Code incoming employee expense reports to the right category*
Who does it today		*The bookkeeper, in Finance — about 6 hours a week*
Who approves its output today (the signer)		*The controller — signs the coding before it's reimbursed*
What the task touches (data class)		*Payroll + merchant terms → money · Confidential*
Why you chose it as your First Move		*Execution work, high time-drain, decided 'automate' in Tasks, Not Jobs*

The Automatability Scorecard

First three columns: higher is more automatable. Last three (weird / judgment / systems): higher pushes AWAY from automation. Verdict bands are Build now / Not yet / Keep it human — never a traffic light. The band is a floor, not a ceiling.

Task (never the tool)	Data availability	Rule-clarity	Exception rate	Judgment content	Integration surface	Verdict band	Flag	Pick
Code employee expense reports to expense categories	*High*	*High*	*Low-ish*	*Low (on coding)*	*Moderate*	*Build now*	*Touches money → drafts only, controller signs*	◀
Kick off a new client (intake)	*Moderate*	*Low (not written down)*	*Mod–High*	*Moderate*	*High*	*Not yet*	*Author it, narrow scope, re-score*	
Review which overdue accounts go to collections	*High*	*Low–Mod*	*Moderate*	*High (whole task)*	*Moderate*	*Keep it human*	*Judgment line — a decision*	

The Approach Pick

Four levels, lightest first: 1 Prompt/agent recipe · 2 No-code workflow · 3 Connected integration · 4 Custom build. Start on the lowest level that does the job.

Task	Level (start lowest that works)	Why this level	What a later climb would take (the trigger)
Code employee expense reports to expense categories	*1 — Prompt / agent recipe*	*Structured, repeatable, feeds one system; the SOP-Execution Agent drafts, the controller signs. A money-touch does NOT push it up.*	*Climb to a 2 — No-code workflow only if volume roughly triples, a second entity needs it, or manual copy-paste becomes the bottleneck.*

Your Task SOP

You can't automate what you can't write down. Point the SOP-Execution Agent at this; it drafts from these steps, a named human signs. The exceptions become your test cases in Module 5.

SOP part	Your task	Example — expense report coding
Task name		*Code incoming employee expense reports to the right category*
Trigger (what starts it)		*A new employee expense report lands in the AP inbox*
Inputs (what the agent reads)		*The expense report + receipts; the written expense policy; the category list*
Steps (numbered)		*1) Read each expense line (merchant, amount, date). 2) Match it to a category. 3) Check it against the policy. 4) Produce a draft coding + a policy flag per line.*
Exception rules (if unsure, FLAG — don't guess)		*Missing receipt → FLAG. Over-the-limit charge → FLAG. Personal / non-reimbursable item → FLAG.*
Sign-off (the named human, before anything is reimbursed)		*The controller reviews the draft, edits if needed, and approves the reimbursement. The agent never approves, pays, or issues a reimbursement.*

The Launch Card

If a cell is blank, the automation doesn't go live. The approval step is designed in from day one, never bolted on.

Launch Card field	Your automation	Example — expense report coding
Scope (as small as still works)		*One merchant category only (travel & meals)*
Human approval step (who signs, before what)		*The controller signs every draft BEFORE it posts — no auto-post, ever*
Boundary (where it runs)		*Company accounts + approved AI; drafts only — never a reimbursement or payment*
Data class (what it touches)		*Confidential — reimbursements + expense policy*
Go-live plan (one task, one team, one week)		*Week 1, AP + controller only; the rest of the team is told what it is and isn't*
Fallback if it misbehaves (the pivot switch)		*Turn the agent off; the bookkeeper codes manually — the way it always worked*

Test · Rollback · Yield

Test the exceptions your scorecard flagged. Every automation gets a pivot switch. The yield is a labeled estimate until the 90-day checkpoint proves it — hand the honest read to Signal vs Noise.

Field	Your automation	Example — expense report coding (numbers are a labeled synthetic example)
Test cases (MUST include the flagged exceptions)		*Missing receipt · over-the-limit charge · personal item · over-threshold — plus ordinary ones*
Pivot switch (retune → redirect → stop) + who flips it		*Controller flips it: retune the SOP, redirect odd cases to manual, or stop and code by hand*
Manual fallback (the way it always worked)		*The bookkeeper codes expense reports by hand — no automation ships without this*
Baseline — counted BEFORE (label the number)		*~5 hrs/week on the pilot category (measured over 2 weeks) — synthetic*
After — measured at the checkpoint		*~1.5 hrs/week drafting + review — synthetic*
Yield (label it an ESTIMATE until day 90)		*~3.5 hrs/week back on this one category (estimate) — no 'average', no benchmark*
90-day checkpoint date (on the calendar)		*Go-live + 90, on the controller's calendar, baseline pasted into the invite*
What this yield funds next (the SCALE loop)		*Automation #2 — the proven hours pay for the next task; no big-bang spend*